



Kumar Mangalam Birla (*right*), Chairman, Aditya Birla Group, with Rahul Kanwal

THE CHARMS of springtime Switzerland can distract the most focussed, even the privileged 2,500-odd members of the global elite who trooped into the popular ski resort town of Davos for the 51st annual meeting of the World Economic Forum (WEF) over five days towards the end of May. There was rain, but the heaviest drizzle over their deliberations, conducted in person after a two-year hiatus, was that from the ongoing war that rages in Ukraine.

Europe has perhaps not been so distracted with war ever since World War II ended some 75 years ago. The health of the global economy has been hit afresh, adding to the pain across two years of the Covid-19 pandemic. The world's reserve currency—the US dollar—has been weaponised as an instrument of economic

sanction, inflation has spread far and wide across the world, and higher interest rates and tighter money supply threaten the global growth story. Food and energy security are adding to the climate crisis in the developing world. Investor sentiment has been spooked across markets, including in India. Even the cryptosphere, of which many leading lights were seen at Davos, has been singed by the uncertainty. Plus, a funding drought looms over the start-up story as well.

Amidst this uncertain and festering backdrop, the biggest show put up by any country at Davos was that by India, as state and central ministers, a bevy of businessmen, and members of the Indian steel frame sought to woo global investors and showcase the subcontinent as an oasis of economic potential. Five states, including the